

OLIVER

Orlando doth commend him to you both,
And to that youth he calls his Rosalind
He sends this bloody napkin. Are you he?
(*He shows a stained handkerchief*)

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

I am. What must we understand by this?

OLIVER

Some of my shame, if you will know of me
What man I am, and how, and why, and where
This handkercher was stained.

CELIA AS ALIENA

I pray you tell it.

OLIVER

When last the young Orlando parted from you,
He left a promise to return again
Within an hour, and pacing through the forest,
Chewing the food of sweet and bitter fancy,
Lo, what befell. He threw his eye aside—
And mark what object did present itself:
Under an old oak, whose boughs were mossed with age
And high top bald with dry antiquity,
A wretched, ragged man, o'ergrown with hair,
Lay sleeping on his back. About his neck
A green and gilded snake had wreathed itself,
Who with her head, nimble in threats, approached
The opening of his mouth. But suddenly,
Seeing Orlando, it unlinked itself
And, with indented glides, did slip away
Into a bush, under which bush's shade
A lioness, with udders all drawn dry,
Lay couching, head on ground, with catlike watch

When that the sleeping man should stir—for 'tis
The royal disposition of that beast
To prey on nothing that doth seem as dead.
This seen, Orlando did approach the man
And found it was his brother, his elder brother.

CELIA AS ALIENA

O, I have heard him speak of that same brother,
And he did render him the most unnatural
That lived amongst men.

OLIVER

And well he might so do,
For well I know he was unnatural.

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

But to Orlando: did he leave him there,
Food to the sucked and hungry lioness?

OLIVER

Twice did he turn his back and purposed so,
But kindness, nobler ever than revenge,
And nature, stronger than his just occasion,
Made him give battle to the lioness,
Who quickly fell before him; in which hurtling,
From miserable slumber I awaked.

CELIA AS ALIENA

Are you his brother?

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

Was 't you he rescued?

CELIA AS ALIENA

Was 't you that did so oft contrive to kill him?

OLIVER

'Twas I, but 'tis not I. I do not shame
To tell you what I was, since my conversion
So sweetly tastes, being the thing I am.

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

But for the bloody napkin?

OLIVER

By and by.

When from the first to last betwixt us two
Tears our recountments had most kindly bathed—
As how I came into that desert place—

In brief, he led me to the gentle duke,

Who gave me fresh array and entertainment,

Committing me unto my brother's love;

Who led me instantly unto his cave,

There stripped himself, and here upon his arm

The lioness had torn some flesh away,

Which all this while had bled; and now he fainted,

And cried in fainting upon Rosalind.

Brief, I recovered him, bound up his wound,

And after some small space, being strong at heart,

He sent me hither, stranger as I am,

To tell this story, that you might excuse

His broken promise, and to give this napkin

Dyed in his blood unto the shepherd youth

That he in sport doth call his Rosalind.

(*ROSALIND faints.*)

CELIA AS ALIENA

Why, how now, Ganymede, sweet Ganymede?

OLIVER

Many will swoon when they do look on blood.

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

Do you pity him? No, he deserves no pity.—Wilt thou love such a woman? What, to make thee an instrument and play false strains upon thee? Not to be endured. Well, go your way to her, for I see love hath made thee a tame snake, and say this to her: that if she love me, I charge her to love thee; if she will not, I will never have her unless thou entreat for her. If you be a true lover, hence, and not a word, for here comes more company.

(*Exit SILVIUS.*)

(*Enter OLIVER.*)

OLIVER

Good morrow, fair ones. Pray you, if you know,
Where in the purlieus of this forest stands
A sheepcote fenced about with olive trees?

CELIA AS ALIENA

West of this place, down in the neighbour bottom;
The rank of osiers by the murmuring stream
Left on your right hand brings you to the place.
But at this hour the house doth keep itself.
There's none within.

OLIVER

If that an eye may profit by a tongue,
Then should I know you by description—
Such garments, and such years. 'The boy is fair,
Of female favour, and bestows himself
Like a ripe sister; the woman low
And browner than her brother.' Are not you
The owner of the house I did inquire for?

CELIA AS ALIENA

It is no boast, being asked, to say we are.

SILVIUS

Call you this railing?

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

(Reads)

*Why, thy godhead laid apart,
Warr'st thou with a woman's heart?*

Did you ever hear such railing?

*Whiles the eye of man did woo me,
That could do no vengeance to me.*

Meaning me a beast.

*If the scorn of your bright eyne
Have power to raise such love in mine,
Alack, in me what strange effect
Would they work in mild aspect?
Whiles you chid me, I did love.
How then might your prayers move?
He that brings this love to thee
Little knows this love in me,
And by him seal up thy mind
Whether that thy youth and kind
Will the faithful offer take
Of me, and all that I can make,
Or else by him my love deny,
And then I'll study how to die.*

SILVIUS

Call you this chiding?

CELIA AS ALIENA

Alas, poor shepherd.

CELIA AS ALIENA

There is more in it.—Cousin Ganymede.

OLIVER

Look, he recovers.

ROSALIND

I would I were at home.

CELIA AS ALIENA

We'll lead you thither.—I pray you, will you take him by the arm?

OLIVER

(*Helping ROSALIND to rise*)

Be of good cheer, youth. You a man? You lack a man's heart.

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

I do so, I confess it. Ah, sirrah, a body would think this was well-counterfeited. I pray you tell your brother how well I counterfeited. Heigh-ho.

OLIVER

This was not counterfeit. There is too great testimony in your complexion that it was a passion of earnest.

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

Counterfeit, I assure you.

OLIVER

Well then, take a good heart, and counterfeit to be a man.

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

So I do; but, i' faith, I should have been a woman by night.

CELIA AS ALIENA

Come, you look paler and paler. Pray you draw homewards.—Good sir, go with us.

OLIVER

That will I, for I must bear answer back
How you excuse my brother, Rosalind.

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

I shall devise something.
But I pray you commend my counterfeiting to him.
Will you go?

(Exeunt omnes.)

Why writes she so to me? Well, shepherd, well,
This is a letter of your own device.

SILVIUS

No, I protest. I know not the contents. Phoebe did write it.

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

Come, come, you are a fool,
And turned into the extremity of love.
I saw her hand. She has a leathern hand,
A freestone-coloured hand. I verily did think
That her old gloves were on, but 'twas her hands.
She has a huswife's hand—but that's no matter.
I say she never did invent this letter.
This is a man's invention, and his hand.

SILVIUS

Sure it is hers.

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

Why, 'tis a boisterous and a cruel style,
A style for challengers. Why, she defies me
Like Turk to Christian. Women's gentle brain
Could not drop forth such giant-rude invention,
Such Ethiop words, blacker in their effect
Than in their countenance. Will you hear the letter?

SILVIUS

So please you, for I never heard it yet,
Yet heard too much of Phoebe's cruelty.

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

She Phoebes me. Mark how the tyrant writes.
(Reads)

*Art thou god to shepherd turned,
That a maiden's heart hath burned?*

Can a woman rail thus?



MY GENTLE PHOEBE DID BID ME GIVE YOU THIS



Scene 3

The Forest of Arden

(Enter ROSALIND dressed as GANYMEDE and CELIA dressed as ALIENA.)

ROSALIND

How say you now? Is it not past two o'clock? And here much Orlando.

CELIA

I warrant you, with pure love and troubled brain he hath ta'en his bow and arrows and is gone forth to sleep.

(Enter SILVIUS.)

Look who comes here.

SILVIUS

(To ROSALIND)

My errand is to you, fair youth.

My gentle Phoebe did bid me give you this.

(He gives ROSALIND a paper)

I know not the contents, but as I guess

By the stern brow and waspish action

Which she did use as she was writing of it,

It bears an angry tenor. Pardon me.

I am but as a guiltless messenger.

(ROSALIND reads the letter)

ROSALIND AS GANYMEDE

Patience herself would startle at this letter

And play the swaggerer. Bear this, bear all.

She says I am not fair, that I lack manners.

She calls me proud, and that she could not love me

Were man as rare as phoenix. 'Od's my will,

Her love is not the hare that I do hunt.

ALL

(*Sing*)

Take thou no scorn to wear the horn.

It was a crest ere thou wast born.

Thy father's father wore it,

And thy father bore it.

The horn, the horn, the lusty horn

Is not a thing to laugh to scorn.

(*Exeunt omnes.*)

Scene 1

The Forest of Arden

(*Enter TOUCHSTONE and AUDREY.*)

TOUCHSTONE

We shall find a time, Audrey. Patience, gentle Audrey.

AUDREY

Faith, the priest was good enough, for all the old gentleman's saying.

TOUCHSTONE

A most wicked Sir Oliver, Audrey, a most vile Martext. But Audrey, there is a youth here in the forest lays claim to you.

AUDREY

Ay, I know who 'tis. He hath no interest in me in the world.

(*Enter WILLIAM.*)

Here comes the man you mean.

TOUCHSTONE

It is meat and drink to me to see a clown. By my troth, we that have good wits have much to answer for. We shall be flouting. We cannot hold.

WILLIAM

Good ev'n, Audrey.

AUDREY

God gi' good ev'n, William.

WILLIAM

(*To TOUCHSTONE*)

And good ev'n to you, sir.

TOUCHSTONE

Good ev'n, gentle friend. Cover thy head, cover thy head. Nay, prithee, be covered. How old are you, friend?

WILLIAM

Five-and-twenty, sir.

TOUCHSTONE

A ripe age. Is thy name William?

WILLIAM

William, sir.

TOUCHSTONE

A fair name. Wast born i' th' forest here?

WILLIAM

Ay, sir, I thank God.

TOUCHSTONE

'Thank God.' A good answer. Art rich?

WILLIAM

'Faith sir, so-so.

TOUCHSTONE

'So-so' is good, very good, very excellent good. And yet it is not: it is but so-so. Art thou wise?

WILLIAM

Ay, sir, I have a pretty wit.

TOUCHSTONE

Why, thou sayst well. I do now remember a saying: 'The fool doth think he is wise, but the wise man knows himself to be a fool.' The heathen philosopher, when he had a desire to eat a grape, would open his lips when he put it into his mouth, meaning thereby that grapes were made to eat and lips to open. You do love this maid?

Scene 2

The Forest of Arden

(Enter JAQUES and LORDS, like foresters)

JAQUES

Which is he that killed the deer?

FIRST LORD

Sir, it was I.

JAQUES

(To LORDS)

Let's present him to the Duke like a Roman conqueror. And it would do well to set the deer's horns upon his head for a branch of victory.—Have you no song, forester, for this purpose?

SECOND LORD

Yes, sir.

JAQUES

Sing it. 'Tis no matter how it be in tune, so it make noise enough.

SECOND LORD

(Sings)

*What shall we have that killed the deer?
His leather skin and horns to wear.
Then sing him home.*